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Notes from "The Poppy War" by R. F. Kuang

7 messages

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Tue, Jul 28, 2026 at 2:44 PM

NOTES FROM**The Poppy War****R. F. Kuang**

July 28, 2026

The feeling of commiseration is the principle of . . ." "Benevolence," she finished. "The feeling of shame and dislike is the principle of righteousness.

July 28, 2026

She had bribed a teacher. She had stolen opium. She had burned herself, lied to her foster parents, abandoned her responsibilities at the store, and broken a marriage deal. And she was going to Sinegard.

July 28, 2026

All beings understand their place when they fulfill the roles set out for them

July 28, 2026

The Keju tested the Four Noble Subjects: history, mathematics, logic, and the Classics.

July 28, 2026

History was the easiest to learn.

July 28, 2026

The Empress Su Daji, the last living member of the troika

July 28, 2026

the only permanent thing about the Nikara Empire was war.

July 28, 2026

mathematics

July 28, 2026

was a slog.

July 28, 2026

The third section, logic, was entirely foreign to her

July 28, 2026

If a tree by a well-traveled road has this much fruit, then there must be something wrong with the fruit.

July 28, 2026

No one truly believed—at least, no one who dared admit it. To the Nikara, gods were only relics of the past: subjects

July 28, 2026

Her worst subject by far was Classics.

July 28, 2026

of myths and legends, but no more.

July 28, 2026

White Tiger, the Black Tortoise, the Azure Dragon, and the Vermilion Bird

July 28, 2026

Don't forget what you did to get here." He straightened up. "And don't ever come back to the south. You're better than that

July 28, 2026

you deserve to be here. Do you understand?" She nodded. "Your first day of classes will be like a punch to the gut,

July 28, 2026

Beware of fake currency. You can tell a silver's not an imperial silver if it lands Red Emperor—side up ten throws in a row. If you see someone lying down with no visible injuries, don't help them up.

July 28, 2026

She could see Sineward's famous East Gate from miles off—an imposing gray wall topped by a three-tiered pagoda, emblazoned with a dedication to the Red Emperor: Eternal Strength, Eternal Harmony.

July 28, 2026

We won the war

July 28, 2026

We barely won the war

July 28, 2026

Rin and Tutor Feyrik were given a tour of the grounds by an older student who introduced himself as Tobi. Tobi was tall, bald-headed, and clad in a black tunic with a red armband. He wore a dedicatedly bored sneer to indicate he would rather have been doing anything else

July 28, 2026

There were seven tiers to the Academy

July 28, 2026

Yin Nezha

July 28, 2026

Nothing, except beat him on the exam. Nezha's prickly about his ego. Why, what did you do?" "I gave him that black eye," she admitted. Kitay raised an eyebrow. "Nice."

July 28, 2026

You think that's what the Lore Master teaches?" "Honestly?" Rin picked at the grass. "I think he just comes in here to get high."

July 28, 2026

The class of first-years, no more than fifty in total, sat kneeling in rows of ten

July 28, 2026

Welcome to Sinegard. I am Jima Lain. I am grand master of this school, commander of the Sinegardian Reserve Forces, and former commander of the Nikara Imperial Militia."

July 28, 2026

But we do not train soldiers here. We train generals. We train the people who hold the future of the Empire in their hands.

July 28, 2026

Combat, Strategy, History, Weaponry, Linguistics, and Medicine.

July 28, 2026

And Lore

July 28, 2026

We cull out of necessity, not cruelty. Our task is to train only the elite—the best of the best.

July 28, 2026

Raban, the apprentice who had broken up Rin and Nezha's fight, led them out of the main hall to the dormitories on the lowest tier

July 28, 2026

The women's quarters were tiny in contrast

July 28, 2026

a spare one-story building that used to be a single meditation room.

July 28, 2026

I'm Niang

July 28, 2026

"Three girls in one year is actually a record high

July 28, 2026

I'm from the Hare Province

July 28, 2026

Dragon Province, but I grew up in the capital.

July 28, 2026

Venka was an archetypical Sinegardian beauty; she was pretty in a pale way, and slim as a willow branch

July 28, 2026

I'm from Rooster Province

July 28, 2026

Martial arts is about action and reaction

July 28, 2026

Don't ask questions. Just obey."

July 28, 2026

History was a lesson in humility

July 28, 2026

In the last century, the Empire has fought five wars

July 28, 2026

And we've lost every single one of them. This is why we call this past century the Age of Humiliation."

July 28, 2026

The Old Nikara Empire was the birthplace of modern civilization. The center of the world

July 28, 2026

But empires fall. The old empire fell victim to its own splendor.

July 28, 2026

And so Nika split into the Twelve Provinces, each headed by one Warlord

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NOTES FROM

The Poppy War

R. F. Kuang

July 28, 2026

The First Poppy War was a disaster. The fractured Empire could never stand up against well-trained Federation troops, who had been drilling for decades for this enterprise. So here's a puzzle for you. How did we win the Second Poppy War?"

July 28, 2026

The Trifecta—the Vipress, the Dragon Emperor, and the Gatekeeper—were three heroic soldiers who had unified the Empire against the Federation

July 28, 2026

Don't laugh. The Trifecta were important—without their political machinations, we might never have rallied the Twelve Provinces,"

July 28, 2026

We won because we lost Speer."

July 28, 2026

We won the war because losing Speer made Hesperia intervene. And, uh, Hesperia's naval abilities were vastly superior to Mugen's. They won the war over the ocean theater, and Nikan got looped into the subsequent peace treaty. The victory wasn't really ours at all.

July 28, 2026

We have survived the last century through nothing more than sheer luck and the charity of the west,

July 28, 2026

But this time when they come, we intend to be ready."

July 28, 2026

I'm Kitay,"

July 28, 2026

He was one year her junior and looked it—scrawny, freckled, with enormous ears. He also happened to have achieved the highest Keju score in Sinegard Municipality, by far the most competitive testing region

July 28, 2026

His father is the Dragon Warlord and his aunts have been concubines to the throne for generations. You'd be a prick too if your family was both rich and attractive."

July 28, 2026

We grew up together. Me, Nezha, and Venka. Shared the same tutor

July 28, 2026

Nezha recognized it at the same moment that she did.

July 28, 2026

Shit," he said. "That's a poppy plant

July 28, 2026

This isn't a garden," she said. "This is a drug farm.

July 28, 2026

Admiring our prince?" Kitay strolled across the room to stand next to Rin. "I fail to see how this would be useful in battle,

July 28, 2026

"I thought the Speerlies were dead," said Rin. "Mostly dead," said Raban. "Altan's the last one."

July 28, 2026

What, no introduction?" Kitay asked. Raban looked amused. "Altan doesn't need an introduction."

July 28, 2026

He's not human." "He's not," said Raban. "He's a Speerly."

July 28, 2026

Altan Trengsin learned it in a night

July 28, 2026

After hearing a few words of the song, Rin recognized it as "The Gatekeeper's Touches." Rin knew it from her many trips delivering opium to Tikany's whorehouses—it was an obscene ditty bordering on erotica

July 28, 2026

You're right," Kitay whispered to Rin. "He has been getting high

July 28, 2026

Combat was a soul-sucking, spirit-crushing ordeal, but there was at least the fun of nightly practice sessions. These were guided drill periods supervised by two of Jun's apprentices, Kureel and Jeeha

July 28, 2026

Nezha performed a series of twirling leaps in the center of the room

July 28, 2026

Oh, it's not. A lot of old arts are like that—cool to watch, practically useless. The lineages were adapted for stage opera, not combat, and then adapted back

July 28, 2026

I have a soft spot for martial arts," said Kitay. "Anyway, it's depressing when you see people who can't tell the difference between self-defense and performance art

July 28, 2026

I'm sure you'll be the terror of the school," said Rin. "You can dance for donations. I'll toss you an ingot."

July 28, 2026

Just as you said." Rin dipped her head into a mocking bow. "I only know one kick."

July 28, 2026

Besides," he said, "that look on his face? Priceless.

July 28, 2026

Power dictates acceptability," Kitay mused. "If the capital had been built in Tikany, I'm sure we'd be running around dark as wood bark

July 28, 2026

Venka, who was obsessively attached to Nezha, actively snubbed Rin whenever she had the chance.

July 28, 2026

Altan's up tonight," Raban said. "Nobody wants to miss Altan

July 28, 2026

Fifth-year student Altan Trengsin was associated with every school record, was every master's favorite student, the exception to every rule.

July 28, 2026

A tall, lithe figure suddenly dropped into Master Sonnen's ring without bothering to use the rope ladder.

July 28, 2026

His skin was several shades darker than any of the other students'; a darker hue, even, than Rin's

July 28, 2026

Trengsin. The Speerlies put clan names last

July 28, 2026

Rin couldn't take her eyes off Altan. His movements were dancelike, hypnotic. Every action bespoke sheer power

July 28, 2026

Strong and mysterious," Venka said dreamily. She and Niang giggled.

July 28, 2026

You know how the Speerlies were. Wild and bloodthirsty

July 28, 2026

He's got red eyes because he's Speerly, you idiot," Kitay said. "All the Speerlies had crimson eyes.

July 28, 2026

I'm just as obsessed with him myself.

July 28, 2026

Speer became a Nikara colony during the Red Emperor's reign

July 28, 2026

Centuries ago the Red Emperor had taken the island by storm and forced the Speerlies into military service, turning the island warriors into the most feared contingent in the Militia until the Second Poppy War wiped them out

July 28, 2026

Speer was annexed under Mai'rinnen Tearza, the last warrior queen of Speer. The Old Nikara Empire asked her to give up her throne and pay tribute to Sineward. Tearza agreed, mostly because she was in love with the Red Emperor or something, but she was opposed by the Speerly Council. Legend has it Tearza stabbed herself in desperation, and that final act convinced the Speerly Council of her passion for Nikan."

July 28, 2026

They still believe in shamans down in Tikany?"

July 28, 2026

pledged themselves to their god—the Vermilion Phoenix of the South. But that was only ever a ritual. Not a martial ability

July 28, 2026

Speer was a tributary. Not a slave colony

July 28, 2026

The exam proves nothing. Discipline and competence—those are the only things that matter at this school

July 28, 2026

"Not unless you cut out your womb,

July 28, 2026

You'd rather kill your own people than let the opponent's army walk away?" Irjah asked. "Killing isn't the same as letting die," Rin objected.

July 28, 2026

I confused tactics with grand strategy," she said finally. Irjah nodded. "Elaborate."

July 28, 2026

Thanks for your time, sir. If I make it past the Trials, I'd be honored to study with you." "You'll find a way," Irjah said. His eyes twinkled. "Sunzi would

July 28, 2026

The Keju doesn't mean anything," Rin said scathingly. "The Keju is a ruse to keep uneducated peasants right where they've always been. You slip past the Keju, they'll find a way to expel you anyway. The Keju keeps the lower classes sedated. It keeps us dreaming. It's not a ladder for mobility; it's a way to keep people like me exactly where they were born. The Keju is a drug

July 28, 2026

She fought to still her panic, to force her drowsy mind to think rationally. She felt no acute pain, only a deep discomfort and great irritation. She hadn't been stabbed. She hadn't somehow ejected all of her inner organs. A fresh flow of blood trickled down her leg that moment, and she traced it to the source with soaked fingers.

July 28, 2026

So you're not dying, sweetheart, your body is just shedding your uterine lining

July 28, 2026

It destroys your womb," Arda said finally. "Basically kills one of your inner organs. You won't be able to have children after.

July 28, 2026

But I don't want children, Rin thought. I want to stay here

July 28, 2026

Someone walked inside and paused in front of her. "You're insane," said Venka.

July 28, 2026

He looks at you and licks his lips. He brings you to the bed. He forces a hand between your legs. You scream, but no one hears you.

July 28, 2026

She began to burn herself again. She found release in the pain; it was comforting, familiar. It was a trade-off she was well used to. Success required sacrifice. Sacrifice meant pain. Pain meant success.

July 28, 2026

But the misery she felt now was a good misery. This misery she reveled in, because she had chosen it for herself.

July 28, 2026

Praise meant that she had finally, finally received validation that she was not nothing.

July 28, 2026

She adored praise—craved it, needed it, and realized she found relief only when she finally had it

July 28, 2026

She craved praise so deeply that she felt it in her bones. And just like an addict, she did whatever she could to get it.

July 28, 2026

In Linguistics, she was second now only to Kita

July 28, 2026

The first day of Yim's class we talked about how losing Speer ended the Second Poppy War,"

July 28, 2026

You must understand that this is a very awkward part of Nikan's history

July 28, 2026

The tactic would have worked. We might have even won the war. But no ruler would have chosen that option, because the country would have fallen apart afterward. My tactic doesn't grant the possibility of peace."

July 28, 2026

She would have been lying to herself if she didn't admit that she derived great aesthetic pleasure from staring at him. With his lithe, muscled form and chiseled jawline, Altan was undeniably handsome.

July 28, 2026

He had the mathematics of fighting down to a science.

July 28, 2026

Are you all right?" he asked. "I'm stuck," she mumbled. "Mmm. Appears so."

July 28, 2026

You're Irjah's pet pupil, aren't you?" Her cheeks flushed. "I—I mean, I don't . . ." "You are."

AHHHHHHHH

July 28, 2026

So am I interesting?" she asked slowly. "You're a walking disaster

July 28, 2026

You know, your footwork is remarkable." She flushed. "Really?" "Placement is perfect. Beautiful angles

July 28, 2026

Not sure. He was here when I was a first-year, but that doesn't mean much. I heard he came from the Night Castle twenty years ago." "Jiang was Cike?"

July 28, 2026

"I thought Altan pledged Strategy," said Kitay. "Altan could have pledged whatever he wanted. For some reason he was hell-bent on Lore, but then Jiang changed his mind and Altan had to settle for Irjah instead

July 28, 2026

Shut up. I have friends." "You have a friend," Kitay said. "Singular."

July 28, 2026

"What, you're not going to be a good soldier to the Empire?" "I will,"

July 28, 2026

What?" screeched a voice from within. Rin jumped. "It's me," Jiang called back, unfazed. "Your favorite person in the whole wide world.

July 28, 2026

He didn't belong—not simply in Sineward, but in the very idea of a physical earth. He acted like the rules of nature did not apply to him. Perhaps they didn't.

July 28, 2026

This is where the statues to the Four Gods used to stand," said Jiang, pointing up into the dark void. "Where are they now?" He shrugged. "The Red Emperor had most religious imagery stripped and looted when he took over Sineward

July 28, 2026

wall for nine years, listening to the ants scream." "Listening

July 28, 2026

legs over the edge like an energetic child. "Ah, I had high hopes for that pig. But in the end, swine are swine. How do you feel?" "I'm devastated," Rin said. "Sunzi and I were finally starting to understand each other." "No, you sod. Your arms.

Your core. Your legs. How do they feel?" She frowned and swung her arms about. "Sore?" Jiang jumped off the wall and walked toward her. "I'm going to hit you," he announced

July 28, 2026

uck it, she thought, and leaped up to embrace him. He picked her up and swung her through the air, around and around among the kaleidoscopically colorful mushrooms.

July 28, 2026

Sir, I just want to learn to be a good soldier," she said. Jiang's face fell. "You and the rest of this school," he said.

July 28, 2026

His eyes were a pale blue color she had never seen on anyone in the Empire

July 28, 2026

Dusky little peasant prodigy, you. He can't stop raving about you."

July 28, 2026

Jiang looked impressed. "Stupid and hotheaded."

July 28, 2026

To spite Jun, mostly." Jiang scratched his chin. "I hate the man. Did you know he petitioned to have me fired last week

July 28, 2026

You don't need Seejin, kid. You need ki. You need muscle."

July 28, 2026

"I heard he got drunk on rice wine last week and pissed into Jun's window," Kitay chipped in. "He sounds awesome.

July 28, 2026

No one in their right mind now would pledge Lore. Altan was the exception, but nobody ever knows what's going on in Altan's head

July 28, 2026

Altan's more or less a god on this campus. Doesn't mean he's happy."

July 28, 2026

Ah. The lackwit and the peasant

July 28, 2026

Privileges like never teaching class

July 28, 2026

I'm Lore Master," Jiang said. "That comes with privileges."

July 28, 2026

How am I supposed to compete with that? Venka's father is the finance minister. Kitay's father is defense minister, or something like that. Niang's family are physicians to the Hare Warlord

July 28, 2026

"I named it Sunzi,"

July 28, 2026

"I've been carrying a pig up a mountain," she said. "Obeying the whims of a madman. Finding a way out."

July 28, 2026

Jun can teach you how to be a decent soldier

July 28, 2026

But I can teach you the key to the universe,"

July 28, 2026

There are five principal elements present in the universe—get that look off

July 28, 2026

your face, it's not as absurd as it sounds. The masters of old used to believe that all things were made of fire, water, air, earth, and metal

July 28, 2026

Fire: the heat in your blood in the midst of a fight

July 28, 2026

the kinetic energy that makes your heart beat faster."

July 28, 2026

Water: the flowing of force from your muscles to your target, from the earth up through your waist, into your arms.

July 28, 2026

Air: the breath you draw that keeps you alive

July 28, 2026

Earth: how you stay rooted to the ground, how you derive energy from the way you position yourself against the floor

July 28, 2026

metal, for the weapons you wield. A good martial artist will possess all five of these in balance.

July 28, 2026

Jiang moved through the world like he didn't belong there

July 28, 2026

Martial arts came to the Empire by way of a warrior named Bodhidharma from the southeastern continent.

July 28, 2026

painting depicting a dark-skinned warrior and a group of pale men in robes. "That's Bodhidharma there in the center."

July 28, 2026

Rin recalled the myth of Mai'rinnen Tearza committing suicide for the sake of Speer's unification with the mainland. Martial arts history seemed to be riddled with people making pointless sacrifices

July 28, 2026

Bodhidharma warned the monks that martial arts was about the refinement of the individual

July 28, 2026

"I am showing you how to beat it.

July 28, 2026

Jiang lay there for a moment, dazed. Then he looked up, met her eyes, and grinned.

July 28, 2026

Don't look at me," Rin said. "It's the end of the road for you.

July 28, 2026

You darling child," he said, spinning toward her. "You brilliant child."

July 28, 2026

I can teach you more than ki manipulation. I can show you the pathway to the gods. I can make you a shaman

July 28, 2026

This is important," Jiang insisted. "Please, Rin. This is a dying art. The Red Emperor almost succeeded in killing it. If you don't learn it, if no one learns it, then it disappears for good."

July 28, 2026

Training under Irjah would be nice," said Kitay. "Of course, Jun's apprentices have their pick of divisions, but Irjah can get me into the Second." "The Rat Province's division?" Rin wrinkled her nose. "Why?" Kitay shrugged. "They're Army Intelligence. I would love to serve in Army Intelligence

July 28, 2026

Sunzi would call it psychological warfare." She snorted. "Sunzi would call it horseshit."

July 28, 2026

No. I mean it was a strategic decision to sacrifice the island so that the Hesperian parliament might decide to intervene. I think the command in Sinegard knew the attack was going to happen and didn't warn the Speerlies." "I was at Speer," Jun interrupted. "This is amusing historiography at best, slander at worst." "No, you weren't," Rin said before she could stop herself. Jun looked amazed. "Excuse me?"

July 28, 2026

Sometimes I think this is as bad as the Speer Massacre," Kitay said cheerfully. "And then I think—nah. Nothing is as bad as the casual genocide of an entire race! But this is pretty bad." "Kitay, please shut up."

July 28, 2026

Unnatural criminals," she said slowly, "who have committed unnatural crimes?" Jun snorted audibly. Jima and Yim looked uncomfortable. Jiang gave a minuscule shrug. "Fine," he said. "That's all I have

July 28, 2026

Nezha looked dumbfounded. Then Kitay began to clap. He was the only one.

July 28, 2026

Not if you help me," she said. "Not if you teach me otherwise." "I thought you just wanted to be a good soldier." "I do," she said. But more than that, she wanted power

July 28, 2026

I'm not—I'm not like Altan." "You are precisely the same."

July 28, 2026

But you. The Empress doesn't know about you." He muttered to himself more than he spoke to her. "You're not safe, but you will be . . . They won't intervene, not this time . . ." She watched Jiang's face, not daring to hope. "So does that mean—" He stood up. "I will take you on as an apprentice. I hope I will not come to regret it." He extended a hand toward her. She reached up and grasped it.

July 28, 2026

Reaching the eliminations in the Tournament was no guarantee of gaining a sponsor, and losing early was not a guarantee of expulsion.

July 28, 2026

son of the Dragon Warlord?

July 28, 2026

She couldn't look away. From a distance, he was extraordinarily beautiful. Up close, he was hypnotizing

July 28, 2026

melodious, soft and deep.

July 28, 2026

Stick around Jiang long enough, and you'll learn plenty of arcane forms.

July 28, 2026

I stole a book from the library," she managed. "He thought that was funny.

July 28, 2026

Because we gave up Speer,

July 28, 2026

Sunzi wrote that one must always identify and exploit the enemy's weaknesses.

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NOTES FROM

The Poppy War

R. F. Kuang

July 28, 2026

melodious, soft and deep.

July 28, 2026

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July 28, 2026

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July 28, 2026

Because we gave up Speer,

July 28, 2026

Sunzi wrote that one must always identify and exploit the enemy's weaknesses.

July 28, 2026

Because I can," she said. "Because he thought he could get rid of me. Because I want to break his stupid face."

July 28, 2026

He gets desperate when he's tired," Kitay had said. "And he's the most dangerous when he's desperate

July 28, 2026

What is wrong with you

July 28, 2026

Congratulations," Jiang said. "You're this year's champion

July 28, 2026

You have stumbled upon something that you're not ready for," said Jiang. He sounded agitated. "I never should have taught you the Five Frolics. From this point forward you're just going to be a danger to yourself and everyone around you."

July 28, 2026

"No. It was my fault. I didn't realize how much like Altan you are."

July 28, 2026

He won in his year, you know," Jiang said flatly. "He fought Tobi in the finals. It was a grudge match, just like your match with Nezha. Altan hated Tobi. Tobi made some jabs about Speer their first week of school, and Altan never forgave him.

July 28, 2026

Altan swallowed his anger and concealed it under a mask of indifference until, at the very end, in front of an audience that included six Warlords and the Empress herself

July 28, 2026

You're too reckless. You hold grudges, you cultivate your rage and let it explode, and you're careless about what you're taught. Training you would be a mistake."

July 28, 2026

Kitay unfurled it. His face split into a grin. "Irjah thinks surrendering was brilliant. I'm pledging Strategy!"

July 28, 2026

She pledged Lore.

July 28, 2026

Defense meetings. You wouldn't know it, but the whole city is on high security alert. The entire City Guard will be on duty all this week. We don't need another Opera incident." "I thought the Red Junk Opera was dead," said Rin. "Mostly dead. You can't kill a movement

July 28, 2026

Is that why you pledged Lore? You think you can become a shaman? You think you can summon gods?" "I don't believe in gods," said Rin. "But I believe in power. And I believe the shamans had some source of power that the rest of us don't know how to access, and I believe it's still possible to learn

July 28, 2026

One might say you've been obsessed with Nezha." "Don't be disgusting." "You are. You're always asking me about him." "Because I'm curious," Rin said. "Sunzi says to know your enemy."

July 28, 2026

Geomancy?" "The artful placement of buildings and things."

July 28, 2026

She couldn't look away. She couldn't even imagine looking away. As the Empress's palanquin moved out of sight, Rin felt an odd pang in her heart. She would have torn apart kingdoms for this woman. She would have followed her to the gates of hell and back. This was her ruler. This was whom she was meant to serve.

July 28, 2026

Kitay, I am a dazed peasant

July 28, 2026

But your mind has just suffered a very particular trauma. The best thing you can do for yourself now is rest. Let the experience germinate. Let your mind heal

July 28, 2026

The Warrior."

July 28, 2026

The Vipress."

July 28, 2026

the Gatekeeper

July 28, 2026

The gods did not send these heroes from the skies. Rather they chose three children—war orphans, peasants whose parents had been killed in village raids. They were born of the humblest origins. But they were meant to walk with the gods."

July 28, 2026

Sixty-five years ago, in the wake of the First Poppy War, the people of Nikan suffered under the weight of their Federation oppressors. Nikan lay sick, feverish under the clouds of the poppy drug."

July 28, 2026

The first hero, strongest among his companions, was summoned by the Dragon Lord

July 28, 2026

The second hero was a girl among the two men

July 28, 2026

The third hero was the humblest among his peers

July 28, 2026

She walked past the Dragon Lord, the Tiger Lord, and the Lion Lord

July 28, 2026

Mount

July 28, 2026

Today we celebrate the unity of the Twelve Provinces," said the puppeteer. "We celebrate the Trifecta. And we pay homage to the gods who have gifted them."

July 28, 2026

Tianshan."

July 28, 2026

I notice the puppeteer glossed over how we actually won the Second Poppy War," Rin said after a while. "You know. Speer. Butchery. Thousands dead in a single night

July 28, 2026

Well, it was a kid's story after all," said Kitay. "And genocide is a little depressing."

July 28, 2026

The Phoenix is a vengeful god,

July 28, 2026

I wanted to," Kitay admitted. "But I'm my father's only son. And my father's the defense minister. So what choice do I have?"

July 28, 2026

Student. Scholar. Soldier. Anything except who she used to be.

July 28, 2026

It's all aesthetics. Supposedly it's important, if your greatest aspiration is to marry someone important."

July 28, 2026

Weird things," she said. "We're studying very weird things." Jiang raised an eyebrow. "How articulate." "I don't know," she said. "I'm just here because I wanted to study with you. Because of what happened during the Trials. I don't actually know what I'm getting into."

July 28, 2026

But how does the existence or nonexistence of the gods affect me? Why does it matter how the universe came to be?" "Because you're part of it. Because you exist. And unless you want to only ever be a tiny modicum of existence that doesn't understand its relation to the grander web of things, you will explore." "Why should I?" "Because I know you want power

July 28, 2026

I think it's cramped from sparring." "I think you're full of shit

July 28, 2026

"The Nikara believe in icons, not gods,"

July 28, 2026

taking the shape of a living god, an animal, a bird . . . The bird lowered its head at them. The Woman burst into flame

July 28, 2026

Plinths," Jiang corrected. "You're right. Plinths." "You saw the Pantheon," he said. "You found the gods."

July 28, 2026

Why not a horse, or a field of jasmine flowers, or Master Jun riding buck naked on the back of a tiger?" Rin blinked. "Is that something you dream about?" "Answer the question," he said. "I don't know," she said, frustrated. "Why do people dream what they dream?" But he was smiling, as if that was precisely what he'd wanted to hear. "Why indeed?"

July 28, 2026

When Hesperians wrote of "God," they wrote of the supernatural. When Jiang talked of "gods," he talked of the eminently natural

July 28, 2026

The gods were simply those beings that inhabited that space, forces of creation and destruction, love and hatred, nurturing and neglect, light and dark, cold and warm . . . they opposed one another and complemented one another; they were fundamental truths. They were the elements that constituted the universe itself

July 28, 2026

Here is what happened: you called a god, and the god answered."

July 28, 2026

"The fact that you're asking," Jiang would say, "is evidence that you're not ready to know.

July 28, 2026

"I'm supposed to take it as true that you're a god

July 28, 2026

Don't be silly. I am not a god," he said. "I am a mortal who has woken up, and there is power in awareness

July 28, 2026

Power dictates acceptability

July 28, 2026

I would call them shamans

July 28, 2026

Those who commune with the gods

July 28, 2026

And so religion is merely a social construct in both the east and west," Rin concluded. "The difference lies in its utility."

July 28, 2026

Because she knew that something was real. She knew that on some level, there was more to the cosmos than what she encountered in the material world. She was not truly such a skeptic as she pretended to be.

July 28, 2026

agree now," she said carefully. "But I suppose I'll change my mind after you've had your say."

July 28, 2026

"It is the nature of all things to have a dual purpose,

July 28, 2026

Opium makes wise men stupid. It destroys local economies and weakens entire countries."

July 28, 2026

opium nuggets smoked from a pipe, poppy makes you useless.

July 28, 2026

heroin

July 28, 2026

extracted as a powder from the sap of the flower

July 28, 2026

seeds

July 28, 2026

These seeds are

July 28, 2026

a shaman's dream. These seeds, used with the proper mental preparation, give you access to the entire universe contained within your mind

July 28, 2026

far she had been pursuing two separate lines of inquiry—the shamans and their abilities; the gods and the nature of the universe

July 28, 2026

entheogen

July 28, 2026

It means the generation of the god within

July 28, 2026

The merging of god and person."

July 28, 2026

results immediately, results that can be duplicated and reused.

July 28, 2026

No. In fact, the opposite is true. The creation of empire requires conformity and uniform obedience.

July 28, 2026

teachings that can be mass-produced

July 28, 2026

fundamental truths about each and every one of us

July 28, 2026

But it has them," she said. "I'll bring shamanism back to this world.

July 28, 2026

The age of the gods is over,"

July 28, 2026

The Hinterlanders were banished to the north, cursed and suspected of witchcraft. The Speerlies were marginalized, enslaved, thrown into battle like wild dogs, and ultimately sacrificed."

July 28, 2026

It was difficult to know that she lived in a world where humans had once freely spoken to the gods but no longer did.

July 28, 2026

But she knew the truth now, and that gave her power

July 28, 2026

The thing about watching someone get high was that if you weren't getting high yourself, things got very boring very soon.

July 28, 2026

You have an aptitude for Lore like no one I've ever met, not even Altan. But you're impatient. You're careless. And you skimp on meditating

July 28, 2026

obsessing over the things in front of you? I know why it's hard for you. You like beating your classmates. You like harboring your old grudges. It feels good to hate, doesn't it? Up until now you've been storing your anger up and using it as fuel. But unless you learn to let it go, you are never going to find your way to the gods."

July 28, 2026

That none of my beliefs about the world were true," Rin answered dreamily. "That reality is malleable. That hidden connections exist in every living object. That the whole of the world is merely a thought, a butterfly's dream."

July 28, 2026

Kitay hated not having full access to information, and she hated keeping things from him.

July 28, 2026

Now that Altan had graduated

July 28, 2026

The matches aren't about winning, they're about demonstrating new techniques. What are you going to do, light up in front of the entire student body?"

July 28, 2026

Nezha was the sole exception

July 28, 2026

Then why don't they worship me?

July 28, 2026

Still, she paid attention to Nezha

July 28, 2026

Mugenese traders and Nikara laborers

July 28, 2026

Mugenese had sent in armed policemen to kill the instigators

July 28, 2026

"And also because you're weird and not as pretty

July 28, 2026

Nikara citizens are dead

July 28, 2026

There's nothing she can do,"

July 28, 2026

The Mugenese aren't going to invade

July 28, 2026

They don't want to make Hesperia angry

July 28, 2026

The Mugenese governor-generals responded by methodically closing, looting, then burning down any Nikara businesses located on the Mugenese side of the border

July 28, 2026

The third crisis was the death of the Federation's emperor

July 28, 2026

Ryohai

July 28, 2026

Prince Ryohai—young, hotheaded, and violently nationalist—was a leading member of Mugen's war party

July 28, 2026

lackadaisical

July 28, 2026

She thought of the warrior Bodhidharma, meditating for years while listening to the ants scream. She suspected that the ants wouldn't be the only ones screaming when she was done

July 28, 2026

They said you'd come," said the figure. The voice was a woman's, deep and sad. "The gods have known you'd come."

July 28, 2026

You will be asked to do what I refused to do," said the Woman. "You will be offered power beyond your imagination

July 28, 2026

The price of power is pain

July 28, 2026

To deviate from their premeditated order you must give them something in return. And for the gifts of the Phoenix, you will pay the most. The Phoenix wants suffering. The Phoenix wants blood."

July 28, 2026

The Phoenix doesn't give. Not permanently. The Phoenix takes, and takes, and takes . . . Fire is insatiable, alone among the elements . . . it will devour you until you are nothing . . ."

July 28, 2026

You should be

July 28, 2026

words in a language that sounded like something she'd heard in a dream she no longer remembered

July 28, 2026

From ashes we came and to ashes we return

July 28, 2026

Shamans: those who communed with the gods. The gods: forces of nature, entities as real and yet ephemeral as wind and fire themselves, things inherent to the existence of the universe.

July 28, 2026

He might, in fact, be the sanest person she had ever met.

July 28, 2026

Jiang looked pleased, relieved, and serene, but Rin only felt confused. She hadn't studied Lore so that she could still the flames. Yes, the fire had felt awful, but it had also felt powerful. She had felt powerful

July 28, 2026

She wanted to learn to channel it, not to suppress it.

July 28, 2026

She thought of the Speerly Woman's admonitions. She thought of the Phoenix, and of fire and pain.

July 28, 2026

She found that she couldn't. She found that she didn't want to.

July 28, 2026

What are you talking about?" He seemed faintly aghast. "Now is hardly the time for this." "Surely there are battle applications to what we've been studying," she pressed. "We've been studying how to consult the gods," he said. "Not how to bring them back down to earth." "But they could help us fight!" "What? No. No

July 28, 2026

one Nikara

July 28, 2026

Cike commander Ty

July 28, 2026

Tyr's shamanic line remained pure and strong through the proven ability of its successors, and only a survivor could be instilled with the gifts of the goddess to pass down to the next generation

July 28, 2026

To be an Empress's assassin meant early death or madness, or both

July 28, 2026

Five years ago he'd thought he might choose the Seer of the Cike, that thin child from the Hinterlands. But Chaghan was so frail and bizarre, even for his people

July 28, 2026

But the boy already had a god of his own. And the gods were selfish.

July 28, 2026

The Empress Su Daji was on this ship.

July 28, 2026

Everywhere he turned, the eyes looked upon him; the great Snake hissed

July 28, 2026

the lost son of the last true khan of the Hinterlands

July 28, 2026

he looked for his commander he saw only darkness and the shattered outline of what had once been human.

July 28, 2026

One: we stand on the verge of war."

July 28, 2026

Tyr is lost

July 28, 2026

Two: we have an enemy whom we love."

July 28, 2026

For although she was forbidden from calling the Phoenix, that did not stop the Phoenix from calling upon her.

July 28, 2026

I can make you great. I can make you a legend.

July 28, 2026

The people who massacred Speer."

July 28, 2026

I wonder what a Federation soldier

July 28, 2026

War doesn't determine who's right. War determines who remains."

July 28, 2026

Have you not listened to a word I've said these past two years? I told you, the gods are not weapons you can just dust off and use. The gods won't be summoned into battle."

July 28, 2026

The Hinterlanders consult the gods for healing. They seek guidance and enlightenment

July 28, 2026

The point of every lesson does not have to be to destroy

July 28, 2026

I taught you Lore to help you find balance. I taught you so that you would understand how the universe is more than what we perceive. I didn't teach you so that you could weaponize it."

July 28, 2026

The god of the Speerlies,"

July 28, 2026

The power would consume you," Jiang said harshly. "That's what fire does. Why do you think the Speerlies never won back their freedom?

July 28, 2026

The fire killed them, Rin, just as it empowered them

July 28, 2026

You're so young," he said softly. "You have no idea."

July 28, 2026

She wasn't so young that she didn't know her country was at war. Not so young that she hadn't been tasked to defend it.

July 28, 2026

I will keep you sane, Jiang had promised.

July 28, 2026

Are you all right?" Kitay asked. "No," she said, trembling. Her voice was a frightened squeak. "I'm scared. Kitay, we're going to die."

July 28, 2026

Thanks," she said. "On your left," he responded.

July 28, 2026

Rin reached out and grasped Nezha's wrist. Nezha nodded curtly in response to her unspoken question. Together? Together.

July 28, 2026

Jiang Ziya," said the general. "So you live after all." "Do I know you?" Jiang asked.

July 28, 2026

Not you." Rin struggled to her feet. Flames continued to pour out before her, flames she had no control over. "You're dead!" the general shouted. "I killed you!"

July 28, 2026

I watched you burn! I watched you all burn!" "Not me," she whispered, and opened her hands toward him

July 28, 2026

I want to hide. I want someone to tell me I'm going to be safe, that this is just a joke, a bad dream

July 28, 2026

What do they call her?" the Empress demanded. "Her"? Is the Empress talking about me? "Runin." Irjah's voice. "Fang Runin." "Runin"

July 28, 2026

It's just a physiological reaction, she told herself. It's just in your mind. You can control it. You can make it go away.

July 28, 2026

imminent truth that she

July 28, 2026

was going to bleed, she was going to hurt, and she was most likely going to die.

July 28, 2026

No, we're not," Kitay said fiercely. "We're going to win, and we are going to live."

July 28, 2026

She registered nothing. Just a temporary shock, then the grim realization that she needed do this again, and again, and again.

July 28, 2026

She did not want to be a legend, but she wanted to stay alive. She wanted more than anything to live

July 28, 2026

She saw Niang slumped in a corner, crouched over a limp body in a Militia uniform. As Rin passed, Niang lifted her face, streaked with tears and blood. The body was Raban's

July 28, 2026

Nezha met Rin's eyes, and then wrenched his sword out of the soldier's back. With his other hand he flung a spare weapon at her.

July 28, 2026

It wasn't as if she could read his mind. She had simply spent so much time observing him that she knew exactly how he was going to attack. They were like a well-oiled machine. They were a

July 28, 2026

spontaneously coordinated dance. They weren't two parts of a whole, not quite, but they came close.

July 28, 2026

If they hadn't spent so much time hating each other, Rin thought, they might have trained together

July 28, 2026

They drew on each other's strengths; as long as Nezha was fighting, wasn't flagging, Rin didn't feel fatigued, either.

July 28, 2026

They fought so well that they half-convinced themselves they might emerge intact

July 28, 2026

Nezha grabbed at Rin's arm. His eyes were wide. "Look."

July 28, 2026

A three-headed lion. A nine-tailed vixen. A mass of serpents tangled into one another, its multitude of heads snapping and biting in every direction.

July 28, 2026

The gods will not be called willingly into battle. The gods will always demand something in return. He was doing precisely what he had forbidden her to do.

July 28, 2026

Nezha pulled Rin to her feet

July 28, 2026

Rin opened her mouth to scream just as the general jammed the bladed tip into Nezha's stomach. Nezha made a high, keening noise. A second thrust silenced him.

July 28, 2026

Please, she prayed. Please come to me. I'll do anything.

July 28, 2026

No stab wounds. That was just Nezha." Kitay didn't laugh. "Is it true? You're locked down here, so it must be."

July 28, 2026

The Militia hates Speerlies." "The Militia is afraid of Speerlies

July 28, 2026

But there's already a Speerly in the Militia," she said. "What about Altan?" Irjah's beard twitched. "Would you like to meet your commander?"

July 28, 2026

She's another Altan."

July 28, 2026

The Gatekeeper's been dealt with."

July 28, 2026

don't know what happened," she said. "It was all just a blur. And I don't know what I am. I was a war orphan. I could be from anywhere. I could be anyone."

July 28, 2026

Altan survived," Kitay said. "You survived."

July 28, 2026

Rin had simply been relieved that Nezha wasn't dead. She hadn't considered that the alternative might be worse.

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Tue, Jul 28, 2026 at 2:48 PM

NOTES FROM

The Poppy War

R. F. Kuang

July 28, 2026

Nezha couldn't live with himself if he couldn't fight."

July 28, 2026

It was the division Kitay had always dreamed of joining.

July 28, 2026

That's great. That's what you wanted, right?"

July 28, 2026

Irjah. I'm shipping out tomorrow."

July 28, 2026

alive. He seemed to have vanished into the very void that he had called into being.

July 28, 2026

They're saying you're a Speerly.

July 28, 2026

"I raised Altan after the Second War," said Irjah. "I know.

July 28, 2026

Sir, I was hoping I could join the Second with Kitay

July 28, 2026

You're not joining the Second. You're not joining any of the Twelve Divisions."

July 28, 2026

The Warlords have decided it best to send you to join the Cike."

July 28, 2026

The Cike? That infamous thirteenth division, the Empress's squad of assassins?

July 28, 2026

I thought I was a good soldier."

July 28, 2026

Oh, Rin. You are. You are an incredible soldier."

July 28, 2026

The Nikara have never been good at dealing with what they don't understand, and Speer has always made the Nikara uncomfortable. I expect you now know why."

July 28, 2026

I recommended you to the Cike. And I did it for you, child." Irjah

July 28, 2026

the Twelve Warlords would be very eager to get their hands on a Speerly

July 28, 2026

What

July 28, 2026

Rin swallowed, fighting a ridiculous urge to sweep her hair behind her ears. She felt a familiar flush, a heat starting at the tops of her ears

July 28, 2026

Hi," said Altan Trengsin. "What was that about losers and rejects?"

July 28, 2026

Altan. Altan Trengsin. She tried to form a coherent response, but all she could process was that her childhood hero was standing before her.

July 28, 2026

How do you exist?" he asked quietly. "I thought I was the only one left."

July 28, 2026

I'm going crazy, she thought. I have become everything that Jiang warned me against.

July 28, 2026

Hey. Hey."

July 28, 2026

It's okay," he said. "I know. I know what it's like. I'm going to help you."

July 28, 2026

No. We're assassins. In wartime, though, we function as the Thirteenth Division."

July 28, 2026

There's no peacetime for the Cike. There's never a shortage of people the Empress wants dead

July 28, 2026

Khurdalain," Altan said. "Tiger Province. It'll be two weeks' march south until we get to the Western Murui River, and then we'll catch a ride down to the port."

July 28, 2026

Khurdalain was a coastal port city by the eastern Nariin Sea, a thriving center of international trade

July 28, 2026

Why can't they just unite like they did during the Second War?

July 28, 2026

Because the Dragon Emperor is dead,

July 28, 2026

He can't rally the Warlords to him this time, and the Empress can't command the same allegiance that he did. Oh, the Warlords will kowtow to Sinegard and swear vows of loyalty to the Empress's face, but when it comes to it, they'll put their own provinces first."

July 28, 2026

We're the final front," said Altan. "If we fail, this country's lost." He clapped her on the shoulder. "Excited

July 28, 2026

Trengsin." "Qara." "That's our Speerly?" "That's her."

July 28, 2026

How are our people?" "Fine," said Qara. "Well. Mostly fine." "When's your brother back?"

July 28, 2026

A couple hundred," Altan said, but Qara shook her head. "Not anymore. They've cleared out since the attack on Sinegard. Their government sent a ship for them.

July 28, 2026

She's the Speerly, Enki." "Oh! I'd forgotten."

July 28, 2026

How did you slip through Mugen's fingers?" "I don't know," said Rin. "I only just found out myself."

July 28, 2026

"Suni's mom fucked a monkey,"

July 28, 2026

need to clear your mind and concentrate. Concentrate on me. Not my weapon."

July 28, 2026

You're reacting based on fear," Altan said. "You're not controlling this fight

July 28, 2026

It's a bit hard when you're trying to jab my eyes out

July 28, 2026

Learn to tame it," Altan said. "Learn to sink in and out of it

July 28, 2026

Focus on what you want to kill."

July 28, 2026

Training with Altan was like training with an older brother

July 28, 2026

Altan was a much better teacher than Jiang. Jiang was frustratingly vague, absentminded, and deliberately obtuse. Jiang liked to dance around the answers, liked to make her circle around the truth like a starving vulture before he would give her a gratifying morsel of understanding.

July 28, 2026

To have similarities with someone else, similarities that lay deep in their genes, was an overwhelmingly wonderful sensation

July 28, 2026

With Altan she felt as if she belonged—not just to the same division or army

July 28, 2026

She couldn't call the god as easily as Altan could.

July 28, 2026

She was not a nameless war orphan; she was a Speerly

July 28, 2026

But you're a warrior, too. It's in your blood. I'll beat your heritage into you soon enough.

July 28, 2026

"Why a tride

July 28, 2026

Longer reach

July 28, 2026

It's like a prayer

July 28, 2026

Jiang had taught her the opposite of that. Jiang had asked her to clear her mind in meditation

July 28, 2026

to forget her own ego

July 28, 2026

Altan looked amazed

July 28, 2026

Jiang had taught her to erase her own will

July 28, 2026

He said the gods weren't meant to be weaponized. Only consulted.

July 28, 2026

That's useless

July 28, 2026

Jiang was a scholar. I am a soldier. He was concerned with theology; I am concerned with how to destroy

July 28, 2026

But Altan controlled it like an extension of his own self

July 28, 2026

The gods are unpredictable

July 28, 2026

Sinegard and Tikany were both landlocked regions

July 28, 2026

Never seen the ocean before?"

July 28, 2026

Altan took her hand and pointed it out toward the ocean

July 28, 2026

And if you take a ship south of there, down close by Golyn Niis and into Snake Province, you'll get to Speer."

July 28, 2026

The Federation of Mugen lies just across the narrow strait

July 28, 2026

Speer? Speer was beautiful

July 28, 2026

The Speerlies divided the night sky into sixty-four houses of constellations, one for each god. And as long as you could find the southern star of the Phoenix, you could always find your way back to Speer

July 28, 2026

Come on," he said, and reached for her arm. "We're going to fall behind

July 28, 2026

She's a Hinterlander," Altan said, and grabbed her arm just as she stumbled against the rickety stairs. "Don't trip."

July 28, 2026

The Dragon Emperor had expelled the foreigners from Nikan in the days of turmoil following the Second Poppy War,

July 28, 2026

Khurdalain might be a louder, dirtier version of Sinegard

July 28, 2026

Because Khurdalain is not a city that you can easily leave," said Qara. "Most of the people here make their living from fishing or in the factories

July 28, 2026

The people are determined to stay, and we'll just have to make sure they stay alive.

July 28, 2026

Are you Altan's lieutena

July 28, 2026

Not me. My brother

July 28, 2026

Forget about approval or rankings or glory, or whatever bullshit you were angling for at Sinegard

July 28, 2026

A shaman who's addicted is better off dead."

July 28, 2026

In this line of work?" Enki said. "It's almost inevitable.

July 28, 2026

Baji was a thickly built mercenary type with a loud booming voice

July 28, 2026

He looked like one of the Fangs' opium smugglers

July 28, 2026

We're anchor twins, not mirror-wells."

July 28, 2026

Suni was a giant man with a boyish face.

July 28, 2026

I like Ramsa," she offered. "He's a charmer. Like a new puppy. You think he's adorable until he pisses on the furniture."

July 28, 2026

Tung oil, sal ammoniac, scallion juice, and feces." Ramsa rattled off the ingredients with relish. Altan looked faintly alarmed. "Whose feces?"

July 28, 2026

The Federation was locked in. Time for the real attack

July 28, 2026

he adored Altan like an older brother. It was hard not to feel the same

July 28, 2026

How'd they take it?" Altan smiled

July 28, 2026

I'm sorry," she said in a small voice. "No, it's my fault."

July 28, 2026

You don't need to open your mind to all sixty-four deities. You only need our god. You only need the fire." "But Jiang said that was dangerous.

July 28, 2026

Who is imprisoned in the Chuluu Korikh? Unnatural criminals, who have committed unnatural crimes.

July 28, 2026

Then how do you do it? How do you make it stop?" Altan leaned back away from the flames. "I don't," he said.

July 28, 2026

My only god is science. Combine six parts sulfur, six parts saltpeter, and one part birthwort herb, and you've got fire powder. Formulaic. Dependable. Doesn't change

July 28, 2026

I really do, but I like having my mind to myself."

July 28, 2026

The Ox Warlord's a slimy politician, and the Ram Warlord is an insecure fool who'll bend whichever way the wind blows

July 28, 2026

None of them seem to realize we're in a war zone,"

July 28, 2026

They're killers by profession

July 28, 2026

Qara's the best archer I've seen and probably the most useful of the lot, but she's mediocre in hand-to-hand

July 28, 2026

The Militia hates us because we have unlimited access to psychedelics, we can do what they can't, and they don't understand why.

July 28, 2026

Chaghan's a walking psychospiritual bomb, but only when he's here

July 28, 2026

And I want to sleep with the Empress." Baji looked around. "Sorry, I thought we were voicing our fantasies."

July 28, 2026

Right." Ramsa chuckled. "I love Speerlies.

July 28, 2026

Altan's attention to detail was remarkable

July 28, 2026

Amateurs obsess over strategy, Irjah had once told their class. Professionals obsess over logistics

July 28, 2026

He called the fire as casually as one might whistle. It was an extension of him that he could manipulate with no concentration at all.

July 28, 2026

Tiger's tits," Altan muttered. "He wasn't joking about the feces."

July 28, 2026

A Sinegard-trained martial artist was worth four Militia men. But Suni and Baji were each worth at least ten

July 28, 2026

The language of Speer was primal, guttural, and savage

July 28, 2026

It sounded like a curse. It sounded like a condemnation.

July 28, 2026

She didn't want to be possessed. She wanted to remain free

July 28, 2026

Three sets of countervailing orders competed for priority in her mind—Jiang's mandate to empty her mind, Altan's insistence that she hone her anger

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Tue, Jul 28, 2026 at 2:50 PM

NOTES FROM

The Poppy War

R. F. Kuang

July 28, 2026

This was a fully grown Speerly. This was a god in a man.

July 28, 2026

It made sense, she thought wildly, that the Cike became living manifestations of their god

July 28, 2026

They should have been able to burn down the world.

July 28, 2026

"I am nothing to the glory that is the Emperor. By his favor I am made clean. By his grace I am given purpose. It is an honor to serve. It is an honor to live. It is an honor to die. For Ryohai. For Ryohai. For—"

July 28, 2026

Altan was so solemnly competent, so casually brilliant, that all she wanted was to please him.

PFTTT

July 28, 2026

I'm very pleased with your performance today.

July 28, 2026

I don't know," she said. "I didn't know him well at Sinegard.

July 28, 2026

Does this mean the Speerlies aren't extinct after all?" he inquired. "Are you and Altan going to make babies and repopulate the Speerly race?"

July 28, 2026

Not likely," she said.

July 28, 2026

No, I mean I can't," she said. "I can't have children."

July 28, 2026

I had my womb destroyed at the Academy

July 28, 2026

It was, um, interfering with my training."

July 28, 2026

Everything about Speer is sad."

July 28, 2026

Every version she heard of the myth made Tearza seem more and more stupid.

July 28, 2026

That myth is Nikara propaganda

July 28, 2026

"I would tell it not as a love story, but as a story of gods and humans."

July 28, 2026

I think Tearza was wise. And I think that she was a bad ruler. Shamans should know when to resist the power of the gods. That is wisdom.

July 28, 2026

But rulers should do everything in their power to save their country. That is responsibility

July 28, 2026

In those days, to rule Speer meant serving the Phoenix.

July 28, 2026

Couldn't concentrate," she said. Got scared. Held off. Did everything you told me not to do.

July 28, 2026

He was trying to protect me,"

July 28, 2026

Great danger is always associated with great power.

July 28, 2026

The difference between the great and the mediocre is that the great are willing to take that risk."

July 28, 2026

Jiang was a coward

July 28, 2026

He was still my master,"

July 28, 2026

Don't ever let go of that anger. Rage gives you power. Caution does not."

July 28, 2026

He's not your master anymore

July 28, 2026

You have a commander

July 28, 2026

The easiest shortcut to the state is anger. Build on your anger

July 28, 2026

And yet, Jiang's warnings echoed in the back of her mind.

July 28, 2026

Was that the price of power? For her mind to shatter, like Suni's clearly had? Would she become neurotically paranoid, like Unegen?

July 28, 2026

He gave an incredible illusion of sanity and stability, whatever was going on below his dispassionate mask.

July 28, 2026

had little control of herself, less still of the fires pouring out of her. Scared of being consumed by the fire, becoming a conduit that demanded more and more sacrifice for her god.

July 28, 2026

"Think of it like a candle," he said. "Difficult to light. Only this is even more difficult to extinguish, and if you're not careful, you'll burn yourself.

July 28, 2026

You've left a thousand starving enemy soldiers in the wetlands with no supplies and no food," Jun said slowly. "Yes," Altan said. "Isn't that a good thing?"

July 28, 2026

All eyes turned to Altan. Rin was amazed at the subtle interdivisional politics at play

July 28, 2026

All citizens will be pardoned, on the condition that they swear allegiance to the Emperor Ryohai." "Pause," said Altan. "You're asking us to surrender to you?"

July 28, 2026

You must be the Speerly from the marsh." "I am." Altan said. "And I'll be the one who accepts your surrender.

July 28, 2026

Why didn't you?" Rin asked. The girl glared at her. Her eyes were hollow, accusatory. "You think we had anywhere to go?"

July 28, 2026

They treated him now with deference instead of condescension, consulted him in their war councils, and not only listened to Cike intelligence but acted on it.

July 28, 2026

If we reject their surrender, then this war goes on until one party has decimated the other. Khurdalain can't hold out that long

July 28, 2026

Their hair was the same pitch-black as Nezha's, their skin as pale as any northerner's.

July 28, 2026

Federation soldiers so closely resembled her own people.

July 28, 2026

they looked more like Sinegardians than Rin and Altan did.

July 28, 2026

The Emperor Ryohai is impressed with the resistance at Khurdala

July 28, 2026

The Nikara Empire belongs to the past. We will raze your country to the ground."

July 28, 2026

"That's saltpeter!" he shrieked. "That's not salt, it's saltpeter."

July 28, 2026

He mouthed the words. "Are you all right?"

July 28, 2026

She felt so utterly, entirely useless. Even if she could call the Phoenix then, summoning fire now would not save this man from dying.

July 28, 2026

Because all the Cike knew how to do was destroy

July 28, 2026

For all their powers, for all their gods, they couldn't protect their people. Couldn't reverse time. Couldn't bring back the dead.

July 28, 2026

But Khurdalain was resilient. Khurdalain had survived two Poppy Wars. Khurdalain knew how to deal with devastation.

July 28, 2026

But we have gods. They can't defeat us on an open field.

July 28, 2026

The confidence is touching, Trengsin, but this is a suicide mission."

July 28, 2026

We have eight soldiers.

July 28, 2026

I don't understand," Altan said. "You've done this before. You did this at Sinegard. What's stopping you?"

July 28, 2026

She was afraid.

July 28, 2026

Afraid that the power would consume her. Afraid she might rip a hole into the void, like Jiang had, and that she would disappear into the very power that she had called. Despite what Altan had told her, she could not just ignore two years of Jiang's teachings

July 28, 2026

Don't give in," the Woman said. "You've been so brave . . . but it takes more bravery to resist the power. That boy couldn't do it, and you are so close to giving in . . . but that's what it wants, that's precisely what it's planned

July 28, 2026

The nature of this god is to destroy

July 28, 2026

greedy

July 28, 2026

satisfied with what he has consumed. Be careful .

July 28, 2026

His chest rose and fell, and then his breathing slowed. She thought she had seen fear in his eyes, but then he swallowed and an impassive mask slid over his face

July 28, 2026

I don't know," he said after a long moment. "I don't know what I'm doing

July 28, 2026

But Rin was looking past the flag at a face in the ranks—a boy, a beautiful boy with the palest skin and lovely almond eyes, walking on his own two legs as if his spine had never been severed

July 28, 2026

As if he had never been impaled on a general's halberd.

July 28, 2026

Their eyes met under the moonlight. Rin's heart leaped

July 28, 2026

You're really all better?" "Near enough," said Nezha. "They sent me down with the next shipment of soldiers as soon as I could walk."

July 28, 2026

Three months," she marveled. "And Kitay said you were never going to walk again." "He exaggerated," he said. "I got lucky.

July 28, 2026

"I'll ask Suni to avoid your particular tent." "Would you?"

July 28, 2026

Maybe you're not a Speerly." "Maybe.

July 28, 2026

What's that supposed to mean?" "It means I won't allow it," said

July 28, 2026

Altan, you're hurting me." His grip only tightened. "You could at least fucking try—"

July 28, 2026

I've tried!" she exploded. "It's not easy, all right? I can't just . . . I'm not you." "Are you a toddler?"

July 28, 2026

Have you been crying?" Nezha demanded as he sat down across from her. "Go away," she mumbled

July 28, 2026

Was it Altan? Did he say something?" She looked away pointedly. "Wait. What's that?" Nezha reached for her collarbone. She slapped his hand away and yanked at her uniform. "You're just going to sit there and take it?" Nezha asked in disbelief. "I remember a girl who punched me in the face for uttering an ill word about her teacher

July 28, 2026

They're saying he's gone mad in the Fifth, but I never thought he'd actually resort to this." "You don't get to talk,

July 28, 2026

Altan's different," Rin said. "Not so different that he gets to talk to you like that

July 28, 2026

You almost got me expelled!" "And you almost killed me,"

July 28, 2026

I'm not supposed to be talking to you," she said stiffly to the wall. "Fine," Nezha snapped. "Sorry I tried. I'll leave you alone, then."

NOOOOOOOOOOOOO

July 28, 2026

warned you not to evacuate without giving notice." "This isn't me," said Jun. "They're running from something." "From what?" "Damned if I know,

July 28, 2026

You'd be fine stabbing something with your mother's face?" "I'd know it wasn't real."

July 28, 2026

listen to her begging, and put your knife to her throat?" "If I knew there was no way it could be my mother," Nezha said. "The chimei sounds scary only if it catches you by surprise. But not if you know." "I don't think it's that simple,

July 28, 2026

You are obnoxiously overconfident in your combat abilities," said Nezha. "I thrashed you at school. I'm frank about my combat abilities,

July 28, 2026

Where do you think—" she began to ask, but Nezha clamped a cold hand over her mouth. "Listen," he whispered.

July 28, 2026

Rin." This time it spoke in Altan's voice. This time she couldn't stop herself from looking.

July 28, 2026

You can't kill me," Altan hissed. "You love me." "I don't love you," Rin said. "And I can kill anything."

July 28, 2026

Don't be," Rin said. She lay slumped against the wall beside him. The entire contents of her stomach were splattered on the sidewalk. "It's not your fault." "It is my fault. You didn't freeze when you saw it." "I did freeze. An entire squadron froze

July 28, 2026

And you helped me snap out of it. Don't blame yourself." "I was stupid. I should have known that little girl—" "Neither of us knew,"

July 28, 2026

I used to have a brother," Nezha said. "A little brother. He died when we were young." "Oh." Rin didn't know what to say to that. "Sorry

July 28, 2026

When I killed it, it felt like murder." Nezha gave her a long look. "Who was it for you?" Rin didn't answer that.

July 28, 2026

Nezha stopped and turned to face her. Her heart skipped a beat.

July 28, 2026

human himself. He can't be real, she thought. A boy made of flesh and bone could not be so painfully lovely, so free of any blemish or flaw. "So. About earlier," he said.

July 28, 2026

We're fighting a war. There's never going to be a good time." "Nezha . . ." He put his hand on her arm. "I just wanted to say I'm sorry." "You don't have to—" "Yes, I do. I've been a real dick to you. And I had no right to talk about your commander like that. I'm sorry."

July 28, 2026

Rin broke a wheat bun in half and offered a piece to Nezha.

July 28, 2026

Rin was deeply grateful for Nezha's presence

July 28, 2026

Rin found comfort in having someone else from her class here on the other side of the country, so far away from Sinegard

July 28, 2026

It helped that Nezha had stopped acting like he had a stick up his ass. War brought out the worst in some people; with Nezha

July 28, 2026

though, it had transformed him, stripping away his snobby pretensions

July 28, 2026

It was difficult to dislike someone who had saved her life.

July 28, 2026

Rin found herself wondering why they hadn't become friends sooner.

July 28, 2026

They were freaks. But they were her freaks

July 28, 2026

They're the best damn soldiers in this army."

July 28, 2026

Sounds like battle prowess is the side effect of the madness."

July 28, 2026

He reached out and touched a spot on her temple, beside her left eye. "Altan's irises are red. I thought Speerly eyes were red."

July 28, 2026

Nezha looked puzzled. "At Sinegard. When you killed the general."

July 28, 2026

I know what I saw."

July 28, 2026

Altan wants to see you. His office. Now."

July 28, 2026

You're spending too much time with the Dragon Warlord's brat."

July 28, 2026

Nezha's just my friend."

July 28, 2026

No one is ever your friend. Not when you're Cike. He's spying on us

July 28, 2026

We are not in the same army. We are the Cike. We're the Bizarre Children. We're the force that shouldn't exist, and Jun wants us to fail. He wants me to fail," he said. "They all do

July 28, 2026

Everyone is our enemy

July 28, 2026

How hard could it be?

July 28, 2026

Altan mattered to her. Altan was a Speerly, Altan was her commander. She needed his approval like she needed air.

July 28, 2026

And she did. How was it that he could make her feel so small

July 28, 2026

You're no soldier. You're deadweight. Until you can call the fire, you're fucking useless to me. You're here because you're purportedly a Speerly. So far I have seen no proof that you are. Fix this. Prove your worth. Do your fucking job or get out."

July 28, 2026

Tell me what happened."

July 28, 2026

To his credit, Nezha actually looked guilty. "Rin, I'm—

July 28, 2026

was the war orphan from the south, and you were the rich kid from Sinegard, and you tormented me. You made Sinegard a living hell, Nezha

July 28, 2026

But if he wanted to malign her commander, then she would remind him exactly whom he was talking to.

July 28, 2026

You weren't the only victim!" he said. "The first day we met you punched me. Then you kicked me in the balls. Then you tackled me in class. In front of Jun. In front of everyone. How do you think that felt? How fucking embarrassing do you think that was? Look, I'm sorry, all right

July 28, 2026

I'm really sorry." The remorse in Nezha's voice sounded genuine. "But I saved your life. Doesn't that make us at least a little square?"

July 28, 2026

I was scared of you

July 28, 2026

And I lashed out. I was stupid. I was a spoiled brat. I was a real pain in the ass. I thought I was better than you, and I'm not. I'm sorry."

July 28, 2026

She wasn't even sure precisely what the matter was, only that both were furious with her

July 28, 2026

The mere thought of both Altan and Nezha made her cringe. She knew vaguely that she'd fucked up, that she'd probably done something that she shouldn't have, but she couldn't reason a way out of this dilemma

July 28, 2026

The name was vaguely familiar. Rin thought back to where she had last seen it—somewhere in the library, perhaps, in one of the absurd tomes Jiang had made her read when conducting a thorough investigation

July 28, 2026

Its fur was black, and its eyes

July 28, 2026

Like his," she said, and pointed to Altan. "Red like blood. Bright as flame."

July 28, 2026

As well as anyone else does, sir. I've read the bestiaries."

July 28, 2026

I'll go, too," Nezha volunteered.

July 28, 2026

She should take a Militia man. Just in case."

July 28, 2026

He handed the torch to Rin and pulled her into a side alley where she could avoid the traffic. "Go.

July 28, 2026

You'd know in the back of your mind it wasn't real. But could you do it in the moment? Look in your mother's eyes

July 28, 2026

I will summon into existence beings that should not be in this world.

July 28, 2026

There is a price. There is always a price.

July 28, 2026

Are you mad?" Nezha grabbed her arm. "That could be the beast itself."

July 28, 2026

So what are we going to do, run from it?" She shook him off and continued at a brisk pace toward the wagon

July 28, 2026

Rin watched Nezha in amazement. He seemed to know exactly how to act around the child, adjusting his tone and his body language to be as comforting as possible.

July 28, 2026

Kesegi

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Tue, Jul 28, 2026 at 2:54 PM

NOTES FROM

The Poppy War

R. F. Kuang

July 28, 2026

Kesegi

July 28, 2026

She was killing the chimei. She was killing Altan. Both were true. Both were necessary.

July 28, 2026

She didn't have the poppy seed, but she didn't need to call the Phoenix in this moment. She had the torch and she had the pain, and that was enough.

July 28, 2026

m sorry

July 28, 2026

He was so beautiful then

July 28, 2026

I forgive you,"

July 28, 2026

What did it say that the chimei had thought she wouldn't be able to kill Altan, and that she had killed him anyway?

July 28, 2026

Maybe that was the kind of anger it took to call the Phoenix easily and regularly the way Altan did. Not just rage, not just fear, but a deep, burning resentment, fanned by a particularly cruel kind of abuse

July 28, 2026

I'm not having issues," she snapped. "I was scared at the marsh. I am not now." And that was the truth

July 28, 2026

But Chaghan only looked amused. "Oh, you think he's an asshole?"

July 28, 2026

Go ahead and try," she snapped. "It's not like we have soldiers to spare." Chaghan's mouth quirked into a grin. "Altan did say you were difficult."

July 28, 2026

So you don't respect him." "I respect him," she said. "I just—he's been . . ."

July 28, 2026

Altan won't break," she said. Altan was the strongest fighter she'd ever seen. Altan couldn't break. "Altan is more fragile than you thin

July 28, 2026

The request had actually been conveyed through Nezha, speaking on behalf of his father, the Dragon Warlord, whom Jun had approached because he didn't want to give Altan legitimacy by going to his headquarters.

July 28, 2026

Because at least one of them likes me. Sir."

July 28, 2026

He's Altan's lieutenant

July 28, 2026

The one and only Chaghan Suren of the Hinterlands

July 28, 2026

So you're the new Speerly,"

July 28, 2026

He reminded Rin very much of Jiang

July 28, 2026

Altan said you were having performance issues

July 28, 2026

He's impatient, overdemanding, paranoid, and—"

July 28, 2026

If you ever speak about Altan like that again," he said pleasantly, "I will have you killed.

July 28, 2026

You must understand. Altan is new to command. He's trying to figure out what he's doing just as much as you are. He's scared."

July 28, 2026

I think Khurdalain was a sacrifice for time paid in blood. Altan is going to lose because Khurdalain is not winnable, and when he does, it's going to break him."

July 28, 2026

His entire life he's been put on a pedestal. He was the last Speerly, a national rarity

July 28, 2026

being very good at destroying things, but he won't get any praise here, especially not when his own soldiers are openly insubordinate

July 28, 2026

Oh, come now, Rin. You're being a little bitch, is what you're doing, all because Altan won't pet you on the head and say you're doing a great job."

July 28, 2026

Look, asshole, I don't need you to tell me what to do."

July 28, 2026

And yet, as your lieutenant, that is precisely my job.

July 28, 2026

Your duty is to obey. My duty is to see that you stop fucking up

July 28, 2026

He's Altan's lieutenant." "How come I've never seen him before?" "He's been away," she said.

July 28, 2026

You mean, you have no clue," Nezha said as a fire rocket exploded over his head. "I mean, you have no business asking."

July 28, 2026

heard he's creepy," Nezha continued. "I heard he's from the Hinterlands." "Qara's from the Hinterlands, too. So what?" "So I've heard he's unnatural," Nezha said. Rin snorted. "It's the Cike. We're all unnatural."

July 28, 2026

I didn't ask you to," Nezha said delicately. "I'm just saying you might want to keep an open mind." "And you might want to keep your nose out of my division's matters."

July 28, 2026

I won't leave my friend behind!" "You will do as I command." "But Nezha—" "I'm not sorry about this,"

July 28, 2026

Fuck you," she said. "Fuck you." "Get to your post, soldier," said Altan. She left his office, slamming the door shut behind her. Fuck me.

July 28, 2026

But he can do things that Speerlies can't," Nezha said as they pressed on. "They say he can read the future. Shatter minds. My father says that even the Warlords know of him, did you know that

July 28, 2026

The source of the cry was Nezha

July 28, 2026

Rin listened, and resented him for not being Nezha.

July 28, 2026

You misunderstand the nature of our relationship. I am not your friend. I am not your brother, though kin we may be. I am your commander. You do not argue with my orders. You follow the

July 28, 2026

without question. You obey me, or you leave this Militia.

July 28, 2026

You children, murmured the Phoenix. You absurd, ridiculous children. My children.

July 28, 2026

It was a deep, slow burn. She could almost taste it, the venomous intent, the ancient misery, and it horrified her.

July 28, 2026

Lovers' spat?" he drawled. "Difference of opinion."

July 28, 2026

Shouldn't have harped on about that boy," he tutted. "Altan doesn't tolerate shit like that. He's not very patient." "He's not human,"

July 28, 2026

I'm not here to talk about Altan." "Then why, pray tell, are you here?" "I need you to show me what you can do," she said. "I do a lot of things, sweetheart."

July 28, 2026

I thought you didn't have a problem calling the gods." "I can't do it as easily as Altan can." "But you can do it."

July 28, 2026

And when I returned?" "I was obeying the warnings of my master."

July 28, 2026

More than that and you will be dead in minutes. Do you trust me?" "No. But that's irrelevant

July 28, 2026

You know who I am," she said. "I am the guardian. I am the Traitor and the Damned. I am redemption. I am the girl's last chance for salvation." "I see," Chaghan murmured. "So this is where you've been hiding

July 28, 2026

That's as real as anything gets." "Jiang never taught me about this." "That's because you Nikara are so primitive,"

July 28, 2026

What does the Phoenix want me to know?" The Talwu almost smiled. "Cast the coins six times.

July 28, 2026

Summon the Cike," said Chaghan. "We need to leave this city." "On what information?" Altan asked. "There was a Hexagram." "I thought you didn't get another question for a month." "It wasn't mine," said Chaghan. "It was hers."

July 28, 2026

We can't leave Khurdalain. They need us now more than ever. We're about to lose the city. If the Federation gets through us, they enter the heartland. We are the final front." "You are fighting a battle the Federation does not need to win,

July 28, 2026

But Altan was never allowed to be human,

July 28, 2026

Since childhood, he's been regarded as a Militia

July 28, 2026

Your masters at the Academy fed him opium for attacking his classmates and trained him like a dog for this war

July 28, 2026

himself with your little boy toy?"

July 28, 2026

I've got it, I'm not sure, but there's something . . . someone that's blocking me."

July 28, 2026

I've realized that masters inevitably let you down."

July 28, 2026

she alone was the anchor to her ethereal brother, who belonged more in the realm of spirit than he did in a world of flesh and blood.

July 28, 2026

She understood, now, why Chaghan and Qara had to be two halves of a whole. Qara was grounded, material, fully made of earth. To call them anchor twins was a

July 28, 2026

It'll eat you alive," she said. "The fire will consume you. To find our god is to find hell on earth, little warrior. You will burn and burn and never find peace."

July 28, 2026

The Chuluu Korikh can't hold me," hissed the Woman. "I am a Speerly. My ashes are free

July 28, 2026

Khurdalain is hell on earth

July 28, 2026

She saw Nezha screaming in the fog, and her voice wavered

July 28, 2026

You don't know what true suffering is

July 28, 2026

off. True suffering? She had seen her friends stabbed with halberds, shot full of arrows, cut down with swords, burned to death in poisonous fog. She had seen Sinegard go up in flames. She had seen Khurdalain occupied by Federation invaders almost overnight.

July 28, 2026

That boy is beyond redemption," said the Woman. "That boy is broken like the rest. But you, you are still pure. You can still be saved."

July 28, 2026

I don't want to be saved!" Rin shrieked. "I want power! I want Altan's power! I want to be the most powerful shaman there ever was, so that there is no one I can't save!"

July 28, 2026

That power can burn down the world," the Woman said sadly. "That power will destroy everything you've ever loved. You will defeat your enemy, and the victory will turn to ashes in your mouth."

July 28, 2026

You have no right to remain here

July 28, 2026

You belong to the realm of the dead. Return to the dead."

July 28, 2026

There are no shamans more powerful than me,

July 28, 2026

And this Divinatory is an angle from which we can see the colors on the palette. This isn't really a place, it's a perspective

July 28, 2026

You still think there's a strict binary between the material world and the Pantheon.

July 28, 2026

The gods are painters. Your material world is a canvas

July 28, 2026

To the Talwu, this room looks completely different

July 28, 2026

The time of asking has expired for you. But you . . ." She looked at Rin. "You have never asked a question of me. You may proceed."

July 28, 2026

The Hexagrams are sixty-four different combinations of lines broken and unbroken."

July 28, 2026

How would Jiang pose a question

July 28, 2026

We Hinterlanders do not call the gods down as you do. We go to them. Our shamans spend hours in trances, learning the secrets of the cosmos. I have spent more time in the Pantheon than I have in your world.

July 28, 2026

"Because I am a Seer. This is what I'm trained to do," said Chaghan.

July 28, 2026

The first line, undivided," read the Talwu. "One is ready to move, but his footprints run crisscross."

July 28, 2026

The second line, divided," read

July 28, 2026

The subject ascends to his place in the sun. There will be supreme good fortune

July 28, 2026

The third line, divided. The end of the day has come. The net has been cast on the setting sun. This spells misfortune."

July 28, 2026

The fifth line, divided. The subject is with tears flowing in torrents, groaning in sorrow."

July 28, 2026

The fourth line, undivided," read the Talwu. "The subject comes, abrupt with fire, with death, to be rejected by all. As if an exit; as if an entry. As though burning; as though dying; as though discarded

July 28, 2026

A leader abandons their people," read the Talwu. "A ruler begins a campaign. One sees great joy in decapitating enemies. This signifies evil.

July 28, 2026

You have cast the Twenty-Sixth Hexagram. The Net," announced the Talwu. "There is a clinging, and a conflict. Things will come to pass that exist only side by side. Misfortune and victory. Liberation and death."

July 28, 2026

"Remember that time I said the Trials were as bad as Speer?" Kitay asked. "I was wrong. This is as bad as Speer. This is worse than Speer." It wasn't remotely funny, and neither of them laughed. Rin's eyes and throat were sore from weeping. She had been clutching Kitay's hand for hours

July 28, 2026

I don't need your pity. I need you to kill them for me. You have to kill them for me," Venka hissed. "Swear it. Swear on your blood that you will burn them." "Venka, I can't . . ." "I know you can."

July 28, 2026

"I heard what they said about you. You have to burn them. Whatever it takes. Swear it on your life. Swear it. Swear it for me." Her eyes were like shattered glass. It took all of Rin's courage to meet her gaze. "I swear."

July 28, 2026

Our friend from the Hinterlands might shatter minds, but he couldn't touch Trengsin. No one can

July 28, 2026

think I'd like to go frothing mad," said Rin. "I'd like to lose my head. I think I'd be happier."

July 28, 2026

Kitay said nothing, just held his arms out in wordless sympathy. She collapsed into them. It was absurd that he should be comforting her, that she should be the one crying, after all that Kitay had survived

July 28, 2026

Irbah begged the Warlords over and over again to put aside their differences. He couldn't make them see reason

July 28, 2026

We couldn't dishonor Irbah. Not like that."

July 28, 2026

A general did not abandon his soldiers. An Empress did not abandon her people.

July 28, 2026

How did Mugen become like this?" Chaghan asked wonderingly. "What did you ever do to make them hate you so much?"

July 28, 2026

It's not anything we did

July 28, 2026

I guess we're saving people for once," Baji said. "Feels nice

July 28, 2026

What for? Look around, Trengsin! No one is going to pat you on the back and tell you good job. There's no one left. This country is going to shit, and no one cares—" "The Empress cares," said Altan. "I sent a falcon, she approved my plan—"

July 28, 2026

You've crossed the line." "I'm your Seer," Chaghan said. "I give you counsel, whether you want to hear it or not." "The Seer does not command

July 28, 2026

Do you understand the source of Altan's power?" he asked finally. Rin frowned. "He's a Speerly. It's obvious." "Even the average Speerly was not half as powerful as Altan is

July 28, 2026

I understand now," she said. "Do you?" "I'm sorry about before.

July 28, 2026

How are you doing?" Altan mumbled. "I hate them," she said. "I hate them so much. I hate them so much it hurts. I hate them with every drop of my blood. I hate them with every bone in my body

July 28, 2026

You said you only wanted the

July 28, 2026

Gatekeeper." Chaghan's voice grew agitated. "You didn't say you wanted to release every madman in there.

July 28, 2026

They are not men at all! By now they are demigods!

July 28, 2026

We were supposed to release the Gatekeeper together."

July 28, 2026

"What Mugen has done is human cruelty. But humans alone are only capable of so much destruction

July 28, 2026

This isn't Speer again

oh

July 28, 2026

"Who cares what your Empress says?" Chaghan screamed. His hands shook wildly. "Fuck your Empress! Your Empress fled!"

July 28, 2026

She's one of us," Altan said. "You know she is. If we have her, and we have the Gatekeeper, then we can lead this army

July 28, 2026

This isn't you," Chaghan said. "This is about Speer. This is about your revenge. That's all you Speerlies do, you hate and burn and destroy without consequence. Tearza was the only one of you with any foresight.

July 28, 2026

How dare you

July 28, 2026

Altan was one of those experiments."

July 28, 2026

By the time the Hesperians liberated the facilities, Altan had spent half his life in a lab

July 28, 2026

Did you know they strapped him down and made him watch as they took the others apart to find out what made them tick?

July 28, 2026

Altan likes to suffer in silence

July 28, 2026

It is not because he is a Speerly. It is nothing genetic

July 28, 2026

Your Phoenix is the god of fire, but it is also the god of rage. Of vengeance.

July 28, 2026

You can't stop an avenger. You can't reason with a madman. You think I am running, and I admit to you that I am afraid. I am afraid of what he might do in his quest for vengeance. And I am afraid that he is right

July 28, 2026

Unnatural criminals, who have committed unnatural crimes

July 28, 2026

You can remain Jiang's good girl

July 28, 2026

But I need your help. I need another Speerly

July 28, 2026

If she helped him free this army, would that make her a monster? Would they be guilty of everything Chaghan had accused them of?

July 28, 2026

I'm with you," she said

well, here we fucking go

July 28, 2026

Last chance to turn back," said Altan. She scoffed, handed him a torch, and strode forward.

July 28, 2026

I found him," she said. "Who, the Gatekeeper?" Altan looked confused. "It's him," she said. "Of course it's him.

July 28, 2026

Jiang Ziya. She had found him, finally found him. Her master was sealed inside one of these plinths

July 28, 2026

You don't understand—" "And you do not listen

July 28, 2026

The Seal is breaking. I can feel it—it's almost gone. If I leave this mountain, all sorts of terrible things will come into your world." "So it's true," Altan said. "You're the Gatekeeper."

July 28, 2026

For the Empire? For love of the country? Which is it, Trengsin? What story have you told yourself?" "I want to save Nikan

July 28, 2026

I want to save Nikan." "No, you don't," said Jiang. "You want to raze Mugen." "They're the same thing!" "There is a world of difference between them, and the fact that you don't see that is why you can't do this.

July 28, 2026

You have not cared about anything for a very long time," Jiang continued. He regarded Altan with pity. "You are broken. You're hardly yourself anymore." "I'm trying to save my country,"

July 28, 2026

And you're a coward." "I am terrified,

July 28, 2026

Irjah knew, didn't he?" Altan blinked rapidly. He looked terrified. "What? Irjah didn't—Irjah never—" "Oh, he knew."

July 28, 2026

It's my fault," Jiang said. "I should have tried harder to help you." Altan's voice cracked. "I didn't need to be helped." "You needed it more than anything," Jiang said sadly. "I'm so sorry. I should have fought to save you. You were a scared little boy, and they turned you into a weapon. And now . . . now you're lost. But not her. She can still be saved. Don't burn her with yourself."

July 28, 2026

He had abandoned her. He hadn't even said goodbye. But Altan . . . Altan had not given up on her.

July 28, 2026

from fear or naked rage, she didn't know. "That isn't why—I'm not . . . We don't need him. We'll wake the others. They'll fight for me. And you—you'll fight for me, won't you? Rin?" "Of course I will,"

July 28, 2026

There's a war," Altan said, "and we need the power of the gods." "The power of the gods,"

July 28, 2026

Tyr thought—"Tyr got scared. The man asked for our power, and backed off when it became too much." Altan swallowed. "I didn't want this for you."

July 28, 2026

ou promised us you wouldn't hurt us. I thought you cared about us. We were scared. We were vulnerable. And you bound us in the night, you subdued us with your flames . . . can you imagine the pain? The terror? All we ever did was fight for you, and you repaid us with eternal torture." "We put you to sleep," Altan said. "We gave you rest." "Rest? Do you think this is rest?" Feylen hissed. "Do you have any idea

July 28, 2026

We have become divine," said Feylen. "Do you think we care what happens to mortals?" "I don't need you to care about mortals," said Altan. "I need you to remember me. I need the power of your god, but I need more the man inside. I need the person in control. I know you're in there, Feylen

July 28, 2026

Kill yourself, Trengsin. Die while you still can." His eyes met Rin's over Altan's shoulder. They glinted a bright blue. "Altan!" Rin screamed.

July 28, 2026

Men are selfish and petty," argued Erlang Shen, Grand Marshal of the Heavenly Forces. "Their life spans are so short that they give no thought to the future of the land. If we lend them aid, they will drain this earth and squabble among themselves. There will be no peace." "But they are suffering now

July 28, 2026

You cannot kill me," choked Sanshengmu. "You are bound to me. We are two halves of one whole. You cannot survive my death." "No," acknowledged Erlang Shen. "But I can imprison you. Since you love the world of men so much, I will build for you an earthly prison, where you will pass an eternity. This will be your punishment for daring to love a mortal."

July 28, 2026

They knew not how to plow the land or to sow seeds so they could grow food instead of hunt for it. They needed guidance. They needed the gods

July 28, 2026

You are blind, sister," said Erlang Shen. "You think too highly of mortals. They give nothing to the universe, and the universe owes them nothing in return. If they cannot survive, then let them die

July 28, 2026

To this day, of all the places on this Earth, only the Chuluu Korikh may contain a god.

July 28, 2026

Are you finally going to tell me where you're headed?" Kitay asked. "Or did you call me here just to say goodbye?

July 28, 2026

Altan wants to raise an army."

July 28, 2026

No, you're trying to deceive me. You don't get to deceive me,"

July 28, 2026

I have seen cities burning. I have seen you do what mortals should not be able to do. I have seen you raise fire. I think I have the right to know. Try me.

MY SHAYLAAAAA

July 28, 2026

You can't change my mind," she said. "I'm telling you this as a favor. When we come out of that mountain, I don't know how much control we'll have, only that we'll be powerful. Do not try to stop us. Do not try to join us. When we come, you should flee."

July 28, 2026

Chaghan and I . . . Chaghan had a theory," said Altan. "About the Trifecta. Before Sinegard, when he realized Tyr had died, he'd seen something on the spirit horizon.

July 28, 2026

They trained soldiers at Sinegard," he said. "With me, they did their job."

July 28, 2026

We just need him for one more day," said Altan. "He can die after."

July 28, 2026

She felt the heat of his gaze on her, and tried not to flush. She was not used to receiving Altan's full attention

July 28, 2026

Of course I'm not all right with that," he snapped. "But it's the job. It's my job. I'm supposed to bring the Cike to the mountain when they've become unfit to serve. The Cike controls itself. The Cike is the Empire's way of eliminating the threat of rogue shamans."

July 28, 2026

to obey the will of the Empress, and to cull the force when it's time

July 28, 2026

There must be a way to bring him back from madness. There has to be

July 28, 2026

How is that fair? Suni and Baji were sent to the Baghra desert because Jiang got scared of them

July 28, 2026

She forced herself to believe him, because the alternative was too terrible to comprehend

July 28, 2026

e only person alive who's ever been inside is Chaghan. I've no idea how he got this door open. You ready

July 28, 2026

You are the most powerful shaman in Nikara history! You can unlock this entire mountain! You could command this army!"

July 28, 2026

How can there be more darkness?" she screamed in frustration. Her voice echoed off the cavernous walls. "How can things possibly get worse than this? Even you took the risks, you opened the void . . ."

July 28, 2026

That was my mistake," Jiang said regretfully, like a child who had been chastened. "I never should have done that. I should have let them take Sinegard."

July 28, 2026

Don't you dare," Rin hissed. "You opened the void, you let the beasts through, and you ran and hid here to let us deal with the consequences

July 28, 2026

Master, please

oh dear

July 28, 2026

Mugen, you will ensure that this war will continue for generations

July 28, 2026

ese are gods. They will treat the material world as a plaything.

July 28, 2026

I can control them,

July 28, 2026

You are mad." Jiang's voice was almost a whisper, containing as much awe as disbelief. "You're blinded by your own desire for vengeance. Why are you doing this?"

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Tue, Jul 28, 2026 at 2:55 PM

NOTES FROM

The Poppy War

R. F. Kuang

July 28, 2026

But only because I'm starting to remember who I once was. Don't go down that path. Your country is ash. You can't bring it back with blood.

July 28, 2026

You are mad." Jiang's voice was almost a whisper, containing as much awe as disbelief. "You're blinded by your own desire for vengeance. Why are you doing this?"

July 28, 2026

But what had he ever promised her? Only wisdom. Only understanding. Enlightenment. But those meant only further warnings, petty excuses to hold her back from exercising a power that she knew she could access . . .

July 28, 2026

I'm sorry, sir," she said. "But I have my orders

July 28, 2026

No, I am sorry," Jiang said. "I'm so sorry. I tried to warn you

July 28, 2026

Master, please—"

July 28, 2026

You're Feylen of the Cike. You serve the Empress, and you served under Tyr's command. I need your help," Altan said. "I need you to fight for me again."

July 28, 2026

You're in over your head, little Speerly. You've brought down forces you don't understand into your pathetic little material world, and your world would be infinitely more interesting if someone smashed it up for a bit."

July 28, 2026

I'm trusting you with my life," said Altan. "I know you're in there, Feylen."

July 28, 2026

Jiang was right. The gods had no place in their world. No wonder the Speerlies had driven themselves mad

July 28, 2026

What were they thinking? They should leave, now, while Feylen was still under control; they should pull the stone door closed so that he could never escape.

July 28, 2026

His weight wrenched her arm down. She cried out in agony as her elbow slammed against stone.

July 28, 2026

You are cutting my people open." "Your people?"

July 28, 2026

Then he moaned her name. "Rin." "I'm here," she said, stroking his forehead.

July 28, 2026

Did he hurt you?" he demanded. She choked back a sob. "No. No—he wanted me to talk, teach him about the Pantheon. I didn't, but he said he'd just keep hurting you . . ." "It's not the drug that hurts,"

July 28, 2026

But she hadn't wanted to believe, because she needed to trust that her commander was sane. Because without Altan, what was she?

July 28, 2026

You can't," she said, panicking. "We have to escape here. We have to get out." His eyes were blank, defeated. "Resistance here means suffering, Rin. There is no escape. There is no future. The best you can hope for is that Shiro gets bored and grants you a painless death

July 28, 2026

Altan Trengsin was not invincible after all. He had been so good at following orders. They told him to jump and he flew. They told him to fight and he destroyed.

July 28, 2026

She had mirrored herself against him, molded herself after him; one Speerly after another. She had emulated his cruelty, his hatred, and his vulnerability. She knew him, finally knew all of him, and that was how she found him. Altan? Rin.

July 28, 2026

"I am sick with fury," he said. "And I am sick knowing that there is nothing I can do." "You've blinded yourself. You're a Speerly. You have power," she said. "You have the anger of all of Speer. Show me how to use it. Give it to me." "You'll die

July 28, 2026

Give it to me," she said immediately, hungrily. "I can't," he said. "It's not mine to give. That power belongs to the Speerlies." "Then take me to them," Rin demanded. And so he took her back

July 28, 2026

No," he said. "I'll finish my duty." Panic twisted her insides. "Altan, no.

nooooooooo

July 28, 2026

Altan, please . . ." "It will be harder for you," Altan said. "You'll have to live with the consequences. But you're brave . . . you're the bravest person I've ever met." "Don't leave me,"

July 28, 2026

You know the worst part?" Altan said. "We're so close to home. To Speer. We're on the coastline. We're right by the sea.

July 28, 2026

sighed. "Is it not obvious?" He patted her cheek. "I want knowledge. Our work here will advance medical technology by decades. When else do you get such a good chance to do research? An endless supply of cadavers! Boundless opportunities for experimentation! I can answer every question I've ever had about the human body! I can devise ways to prevent death!"

July 28, 2026

You Speerlies are so special," Shiro confided. His voice had taken on a low, husky tone. He spoke as if to an infant, or a lover. "So strong. So unique. They say you are a god's chosen people. What makes you this way?

July 28, 2026

Because the gods wouldn't bother with scum like you

July 28, 2026

How do you think the Red Emperor kept the Speerlies on their leash?

July 28, 2026

If you give me freedom," she snarled, "the first thing I will do is burn you alive."

July 28, 2026

guards to drag the prisoners into a cell. "I will see you both tomorrow," he said cheerfully. "And we will try this again."

July 28, 2026

It's when it wears off."

July 28, 2026

She had never understood how horrendously difficult it was to be Altan Trengsin, to live under the strain of a furious god constantly screaming for destruction in the back of his mind, while an indifferent narcotic deity whispered promises in his blood.

July 28, 2026

That's why the Speerlies became addicted to opium so easily, she realized. Not because they needed it for their fire. Because for some of them, it was the only time they could get away from their horrible god

July 28, 2026

We fight for the Empress," she said. "I'm a Militia soldier until the day I die."

July 28, 2026

Have you even asked how we knew you were at the Chuluu Korikh?" Shiro asked. "Who must have given us that information? Who was the only other person who knew of that wonderful mountain?"

July 28, 2026

Your Empress gave you up, you and your precious band of shamans. You were sold, my dear Speerlies, just like Speer was sold. Just like your Empire was sold."

July 28, 2026

But now she knew the truth, she knew the realness of Altan and his vulnerabilities and most of all his pain . . . and still she loved him.

July 28, 2026

She could feel him all around her; a hard edge, a deeply wounded aura, and yet a comforting presence.

July 28, 2026

I will die with flames in my hand and fury in my heart. I will die fighting for the legacy of my people, rather than on Shiro's operating table, drugged and wasted. I will not die a coward. And neither will you. Altan, look at me. We are not like Jiang. We are not like Tearza."

July 28, 2026

Then I will die on my feet," she

July 28, 2026

The Phoenix isn't only the god of fire," he said. "It is the god of revenge. And there is a power, born of centuries of festering hatred, that only a Speerly can access. I

July 28, 2026

Altan did not feel even like a separate presence

July 28, 2026

Rather, he and she made two parts of a much greater whole

July 28, 2026

all Speerlies could sing that song before their fifth birthday.

July 28, 2026

This was the golden age of Speer. This was Speer before Tearza. Before the massacre

July 28, 2026

We could stay here," Altan said. "We could stay here forever. We wouldn't have to go back."

July 28, 2026

This is why we are strong. We draw our strength from centuries and centuries of unforgotten injustices

July 28, 2026

After us, there will be no Speer. Only a memory."

July 28, 2026

she realize the depth of it. The weight of it.

July 28, 2026

Our god is an angry god," said the woman who looked like Rin. "It will not let this injustice rest. It demands vengeance."

July 28, 2026

She reached for Altan. They were of one mind and one purpose.

July 28, 2026

Tearza didn't save our people," he said. "I couldn't save our people. But this comes close."

July 28, 2026

She thought for a bizarre moment that he was going to kiss her.

July 28, 2026

You're so much stronger than I am," said Altan. Then he let her go.

July 28, 2026

No," Rin begged. "No!"

July 28, 2026

The fire doesn't give, the fire takes, and takes, and takes.

July 28, 2026

Stay away, screamed the Woman. Stay far away from here. No, Rin thought. You can't keep me away. I'm coming.

July 28, 2026

I warn you one more time," said the ghost of Mai'rinnen Tearza. "Do not give yourself to the Phoenix." "Shut up and let me through,"

July 28, 2026

And what do you want from me?" the Phoenix inquired. "I want an end to the Federation." "How do you intend to achieve that?"

July 28, 2026

Total victory," she said. "It's what you want, isn't it?" "What I want?" The Phoenix sounded amused. "The gods do not want anything

July 28, 2026

This is my destiny," Rin said with conviction. "I'm the last Speerly. I have to do this. It is written." "Nothing is written,

July 28, 2026

Do it," Rin whispered. "Your will is mine," said the Phoenix.

July 28, 2026

The part of her that was capable of considering that no longer worked. Those weren't lives. They were numbers. They were a necessary subtraction.

July 28, 2026

But the sight of Altan walking to his death was seared into her memory

July 28, 2026

feel you," said the Phoenix, undulating before her. "I sense your sacrifice, your pain, and I want it, bring it to me . . . you are close, so close.

July 28, 2026

She saw a storm cloud that looked like a man gathering over the mountains, with four cyclones branching off like limbs, and when she stared at the source, two intelligent spots of cerulean peered back at her—too bright to be natural, too

malicious to be anything but a god.

July 28, 2026

I won't," said the woman. "I will not sacrifice the world for the sake of this island."

July 28, 2026

I condemn you. You will never know peace

July 28, 2026

The Gatekeeper hung in a vacuum, frozen in a state of suspended animation, a place next to nowhere and on the way to everywhere.

July 28, 2026

Wake up," he said. "You're going to drown.

July 28, 2026

The Speerlies needed only one.

July 28, 2026

I'm already in hell," Rin said hoarsely. "And I don't care."

July 28, 2026

To give your soul to the Phoenix is to enter hell. It consumes you. You will burn eternally."

July 28, 2026

If I hadn't given up Speer, the world would be burning down,"

July 28, 2026

How is death and slavery peace?" Rin spat. "I have lost my friends and my country. I have lost everything I care about. I don't want peace, I want revenge

July 28, 2026

I wouldn't have to do this. And Altan would still be alive

July 28, 2026

You know what Altan did," Rin said in a low whisper. "You have him forever now.

July 28, 2026

The boy was broken in body and spirit. The boy was a coward."

July 28, 2026

Rin suspected, had been tired of living

stop this madness

July 28, 2026

You humans always think you're destined for things, for tragedy or for greatness. Destiny is a myth. Destiny is the only myth

July 28, 2026

You chose. You chose to take the exam. You chose to come to Sinegard. You chose to pledge Lore, you chose to study the paths of the gods, and you chose to follow your commander's demands over your master's warnings.

July 28, 2026

And what will you give me in return?" inquired the Phoenix. "The price to alter the fabric of the world is steep."

July 28, 2026

"I can give you worship," she promised. "I can give you an unending flow of blood."

July 28, 2026

frowning. "Shit," he said. "Shit." "What?" "Your eyes," he said. "What about them?" "They look like Altan's."

July 28, 2026

At the sound of that name she began to cry in earnest. "Hey. Hey, now," Ramsa said, patting her awkwardly on the head. "It's all right. You're safe." "How did you . . . where?"

July 28, 2026

That was Altan," Rin said. She felt a fresh pang of grief the moment she said it, and her face crumpled. "We saw," Ramsa said softly. "We figured that was him." "He saved me." "Yeah." Ramsa hesitated. "So he's definitely . . ." She began to sob

July 28, 2026

Sand all around you, and you were on a sheet of clear crystal. It was something like a story. A fairy tale." Not a fairy tale

July 28, 2026

Fuck," Ramsa said quietly. "Chaghan's . . . someone's going to have to tell Chaghan." "Where is he?" "Close. Qara sent us a message with a raven but it didn't say much, except that they're coming. We'll rendezvous with them soon. She'll know how to find us."

July 28, 2026

she thought. She had burned so hot that she had melted down the sand around her. That was no story. It was a nightmare. "How long have I been out?" "About three days. We put you up in the captain's cabin."

July 28, 2026

She wanted to forget everything, to forget the war, to forget her gods. It was enough to simply be, to know that her friends were alive and that the entire world was not so dark after all. But she could not remain inside this happy delusion.

July 28, 2026

So Mugen is gone?" Rin breathed. "They're all dead?" "If they aren't, they will be soon," said Kitay. "I've imagined it so many times. I've pieced things together from what we studied.

July 28, 2026

I told you," she whispered. "I went to my god. I told it what I wanted." He looked aghast. "You're saying—so your god, it—it made you do this?" "My god didn't make me do anything," she said. "The gods can't make our choices for us. They can only offer their power, and we can wield it. And I did, and this is what I chose." She swallowed. "I don't regret it."

July 28, 2026

You just killed thousands of innocent people." "They tortured me! They killed Altan!" "You did to Mugen the same thing that they did to Speer." "They deserved it!"

July 28, 2026

How could anyone deserve that?" Kitay yelled. "How, Rin?" She was amazed. How could he be angry with her now? Did he have any idea what she had been through?

July 28, 2026

What are you talking about?" "I want a war against the Empress." "The Empress?" Kitay looked dumbfounded

July 28, 2026

Was she now a goddess or a monster? Perhaps neither. Perhaps both

July 28, 2026

I should have known," Chaghan said finally. "We have an enemy whom we love." "What?" "I read it in Altan's Hexagram. Months ago." "It meant the Empress," she said. "Perhaps," he said, and turned his gaze out to the sea.

July 28, 2026

No, Altan named his successor before we left for Golyn Niis." Rin jerked her head up. That was news. "Who?" Chaghan looked like he couldn't believe she had asked. "It's you," he said, as if it were obvious

July 28, 2026

You are going to paint the world in Altan's blood, aren't you?" "I'm going to find and kill everyone responsible," said Rin. "You cannot stop me." Chaghan laughed a dry, cutting laugh. "Oh, I'm not going to stop you

July 28, 2026

They were allies, now, bound by the mutual atrocities they had committed. They had a god to kill. A world to reshape. An Empress to overthrow.

July 28, 2026

She was no victim of destiny. She was the last Speerly, commander of the Cike, and a shaman who called the gods to do her bidding. And she would call the gods to do such terrible things.

July 28, 2026

We were rather hoping you'd tell us."

July 28, 2026

And I was right," said Kitay. "I've never been so glad to be right." He rushed forward and hugged Rin tightly. "You didn't give up on me at Golyn Niis. I couldn't give up on you."

*stars sobbing

July 28, 2026

So it's true," he said finally. "You can really call gods."

July 28, 2026

She trembled without knowing why, and then nodded. What was the point in lying to Kitay now? What was the point in lying to anyone?

July 28, 2026

Have you ever considered," he said slowly, "that that was exactly what they thought of us?

July 28, 2026

All of our friends are dead. Nezha. Raban. Irjah. Altan

July 28, 2026

War's already here. A traitor sits on the throne of the Empire," she said stubbornly. "I will see her burn."

July 28, 2026

I don't know what happened to you in that temple," he said. "But you are not Fang Runin

July 28, 2026

have become something wonderful, she thought. I have become something terrible.

July 28, 2026

We avenged him, Rin. He's gone, but avenged."

July 28, 2026

You have to believe that it was necessary. That it stopped something worse.

July 28, 2026

From ash we come, and to ash we return. To the Speerlies, death was not an end but only a great reunion. Altan has left us to go home. Altan has returned to Speer."

July 28, 2026

The Empress should be the least of your concerns," said Chaghan after a while. "Feylen's getting stronger. And he always was powerful. Almost more so than Altan."

July 28, 2026

Altan had named her as his successor. Entrusted his legacy to her. He had written and signed the order in blood before they had even left Khurdalain

July 28, 2026

They had come to an understanding, she and Chaghan. They were no longer opposed, vying for Altan's favor.

July 28, 2026

Jiang was wrong. She was not dabbling in forces she could not control, for the gods were not dangerous. The gods had no power at all, except what she gave them

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